

DarkRoast

Redesigning the project workspace for faster creative collaboration

DarkRoast is a creative operations platform used by clients and designers to manage projects, feedback, files, and ongoing creative work.

I worked across the product redesign, from research and workflow mapping to information architecture and the final client and designer-facing experience.

This first phase focused on understanding how people used the existing dashboard, where the workflow was breaking down, and what needed to change before redesigning the interface.

TL;DR

The existing dashboard had grown into a dense project management interface where messaging, files, briefs, status, and project metadata all competed for attention.

Through user feedback, workflow analysis, benchmarking, and a detailed product audit, I found that the main problem was not missing features. It was **hierarchy, focus, and context**.

The redesign therefore started by redefining what mattered most at each point in the workflow.

The problem

DarkRoast clients manage a high volume of creative work.

They need to know:

- what is moving
- what needs attention
- what is blocked
- where feedback is required
- who is working on what

But the current dashboard made this harder than it needed to be.

Important information was spread across the interface, messaging had limited space, reference content stayed visible even when it was not needed, and project states were difficult to scan quickly.

As the number of projects grew, this created more cognitive load and more manual checking.

Who we were designing for

The primary client user was typically a marketing or sales lead managing multiple creative needs at once.

They were not looking for another project management tool.

They wanted a system that could absorb complexity and keep work moving without requiring constant oversight.

Their main goal

Keep creative work moving at scale without becoming the bottleneck.

They wanted to spend less time explaining, checking, and repeating context — and more time making the decisions that actually required their judgment.

Research

We started with the client feedback that already existed.

Around **150 clients** had responded to a survey asking what they wanted improved.

The strongest themes were:

- mobile experience
- file management
- Google Drive integration
- reliability and stability
- Slack integration
- quoting
- invoicing and billing

At first glance, these looked like feature requests.

The written feedback told a more useful story.

Looking beyond the survey labels

Several comments pointed to broader experience problems.

“Better mobile experience” was also a space problem

Users described:

- chat becoming too narrow
- too many panels staying open
- needing to zoom the browser out
- difficulty focusing on the conversation

The issue was not only mobile.

It was poor use of space across screen sizes.

“Better file management” was not really about storage

Users struggled with:

- previewing files
- knowing which version they were viewing
- finding files inside long conversations
- understanding where an asset belonged

The deeper need was **context and confidence**, not just better file storage.

Small UI failures affected trust

Users also reported formatting issues with text, links, and spacing.

These may sound minor, but in a tool used for client collaboration, unstable formatting makes the entire product feel less reliable.

Small updates felt too formal

Some users wanted lightweight back-and-forth without creating a heavy project-management workflow.

This exposed a tension in the product:

DarkRoast needed to support both structured project management and casual collaboration.

What the research did not tell us

The survey was useful for direction, but it had limits.

It told us **what users selected**, but not:

- where in the journey the issue happened
- how severe the problem was
- whether it affected every project or only certain stages
- what users were trying to do when the problem appeared

The predefined options also influenced the responses.

That meant we could not treat the survey results as a feature roadmap.

We needed to understand the workflows underneath them.

Mapping the client workflow

We broke the client experience into recurring jobs.

Clients needed to:

Turn business intent into creative direction

Share rough goals, references, constraints, and deadlines without writing a perfect brief.

Start new work quickly

Reuse existing context instead of rebuilding every project from scratch.

Delegate thinking as well as execution

Hand over incomplete ideas and rely on the system and creative team to structure them.

Review work at the right level

Understand direction and quality without reading every detail.

Maintain brand consistency

Keep work on-brand across multiple designers and projects.

Iterate without re-briefing

Give quick directional feedback without resetting context.

Monitor momentum

Know what is moving, blocked, or waiting for input.

The common theme was clear:

clients wanted visibility without micromanagement.

Defining the product mental model

The research helped us define a simple way to think about the project page.

A project had two modes.

Active Mode

Where work happens:

- messaging
- feedback
- coordination
- file sharing
- decisions

Reference Mode

Where users check context:

- project brief
- metadata
- summaries
- historical information

The existing product treated both modes as equally important all the time.

That was creating unnecessary density.

Our working principle became:

Give active work priority. Keep reference information close, but not permanently in the way.

Benchmarking existing patterns

Before redesigning the product, we looked at tools our users were already familiar with.

The goal was not to copy interfaces.

It was to understand the interaction patterns users already knew, then use those patterns as a starting point.

File review and version management

Framer
Figma
Dropbox

Feedback in a review context

Notion
Linear
Loom

Project dashboard and triage

Linear
Asana
Basecamp

Activity and notification systems

Basecamp
Slack
Linear
Superhuman

Modals and interruptions

Typeform
Intercom
HubSpot

Upload states and system feedback

Dropbox
Google Drive

This helped us avoid inventing new interaction models where familiar ones already worked well.

Auditing the current dashboard

With the research and workflow model in place, I audited the existing interface screen by screen.

The goal was to understand which problems were structural and which were only visual.

A clear pattern emerged:

the dashboard did not need more features. It needed better hierarchy.

1. Projects were difficult to scan

The project list made it hard to identify what needed attention.

Status, deadlines, assignments, and priority were not visually strong enough to support fast triage.

Clients often had to open individual projects just to understand what was happening.

Impact

- slower project triage
- more unnecessary page opening
- weaker deadline awareness
- more effort to understand who owned what

For a user managing many active projects, this became increasingly inefficient.

2. Messaging was the main workflow, but looked secondary

Inside a project, most day-to-day work happened through conversation.

But the messaging area was squeezed between a large header and a persistent project brief.

Long conversations became tiring to scan, and mixed content such as text, files, images, and links lacked clear hierarchy.

The most important part of the screen had the least room to work.

3. Reference information took too much space

The project brief, metadata, AI summary, and other reference details were useful — but not continuously.

They occupied space even while users were actively chatting or reviewing work.

This was one of the clearest examples of the mismatch between **Active Mode** and **Reference Mode**.

4. Important actions were buried

Feedback requests, pending reviews, and other items that required action appeared inside the same stream as normal updates.

There was little distinction between:

something happened

and

you need to do something

This made it harder for clients to manage by exception.

5. Files lacked context

The files view was difficult to scan and offered limited information about:

- version
- upload date
- author
- project context

As the number of files increased, confidence dropped.

The problem was not just finding a file.

It was knowing whether it was the right file.

6. Assignment and project ownership were unclear

Designer assignment, following, status, and project ownership were visible, but their hierarchy was weak.

Users could see the information without always understanding what it meant or what required action.

This contributed to the broader problem of unclear project state.

What the audit showed

Across the dashboard, the issues were closely related.

Users had:

too much information visible at once

but

not enough clarity about what mattered now.

This resulted in:

- higher cognitive load
- slower project triage
- more context switching
- unnecessary navigation
- weaker confidence in project status
- more friction between clients and designers

The problem was not a collection of isolated UI issues.

It was an **information hierarchy and workflow problem.**

The design opportunity

By the end of the research and audit phase, three priorities were clear.

1. Make progress obvious

Clients should understand what is happening across their projects without opening each one.

2. Give active work more space

Messaging, feedback, and collaboration should take priority when users are working inside a project.

3. Reduce persistent information

Reference content should stay accessible without competing with the main task.

These principles became the foundation for the next phase:

reworking the information architecture and redesigning the client and designer dashboards.